



THEY ALSO CAMPAIGNED: The crowd comes for Modi and not for BJP leaders L.K. Advani and Rajnath Singh

communicator, and he knows how to market himself" adds another admirer, Mukesh Bavishi, a renowned gynaecologist, "and I feel very good about it. He marks a cultural shift in politics." The middle and upper classes feel good about a politician who is terrifyingly honest and clean—and a man with a missionary zeal. The Congress campaign is using this elitist endorsement to portray him anti-poor. "Vibrant Gujarat gets only two days in every two years but every year in June, for three days when the temperature is 44° C, a 700-strong team of top officers go to the villages to promote the education of the girl child," he tells you, and he can go on narrating human interest stories of his government.

Such stories don't make good stump

speeches, though. They don't add to the sex appeal of the last action hero of the Indian right either. The mascot of Hindu machismo needs Sohrabuddin and other demons to fight with. And that is why women and the young chase him for autographs. Some of the girls want to be autographed on their cheek. But he doesn't oblige them. "They know I am a man of purity... They know I'm unattached also. It is motherly love. Every woman wants to be the mother of Shivaji." Maybe the man needs such comforting fantasies. He still suffers from an image crisis. Modi may have come a long way from Gujarat 2002 to become a development junkie—and a possible Davos attraction. Once an international "untouchable" (even Ahmedinejad got a better deal from the U.S.), he con-

tinues to be a figure of hate in the left-liberal seminar rooms—and a section of the commentary can't say that four-letter word without a nasty adjective from history. Modi still divides the mind of India. His victory, though, will radically transform the Indian right. The ideology of robust Hindutva will be back, and for the party, the third consecutive win in Gujarat will be a national boost. A defeat will be the end of the road for Modi as well as Moditva; some in the party will rejoice, and some outside will call it poetic justice. There is only one name between victory and defeat, and that is Modi.

Beneath the brio and bravado of the fighter, there is anxiety. As the Toyota SUV nears the Baroda airport, it is past midnight. Suddenly, looking straight into your eyes, Modi has this question, "Tell me, will the nation realise my worth if I win this election?" A few minutes later, he is a walking towards the tarmac, where a chopper is waiting to take him to Ahmedabad. It was the walk of a man who had known the answer all the while.

with Uday Mahurkar



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